

2026-05-14 — Cohesity PoC Post Vendor Chat

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Attendees	Ross Bell, Becky Boardman, John Cameron, Dale Butts, Olufunwa, Angela, Magson, Matthew, Daniel Kaminski, David Gee
Duration	~53 minutes
Source	[PROCESSED] Cohesity PoC - Post Vendor Chat.vtt, [PROCESSED] Cohesity PoC - Post Vendor Chat Cont.vtt

TL;DR

The team will adopt a "find the zero" strategy to identify deal-breaker requirements for the Cohesity POC, centralize all project communication in the El Capitan channel, and reuse existing N2W requirements as a starting point — with David Gee presenting the initiative to TDA on Monday to bridge an organizational awareness gap.

Decisions, action items, and ownership below are captured from the AI extraction only. Actual status and assignments are tracked via the ADO Kanban board. Ownership is AI-inferred from speech patterns unless a participant explicitly committed — confirm assignments on the board.

Decisions

- **D1 (Accepted):** We will use the "find the zero" / load-bearing assumptions strategy to identify and prioritize POC requirements for Cohesity — testing deal-breaker requirements first before investing in broader evaluation. Owner: Ross Bell, Becky Boardman.
- **D2 (Accepted):** We will centralize all project chat in the El Capitan Teams channel, rather than spreading discussion across separate chats. Owner: Becky Boardman.
- **D3 (Accepted):** We will keep all project documentation in a shared central location. Owner: Ross Bell.

- **D4 (Accepted):** We will review and adapt the existing N2W requirements document as the starting point for Cohesity POC requirements, combined with the zero requirements identified through D1.
Owner: Ross Bell, Olufunwa, Angela.

Action items

Owner	Action	Due	Status
Ross Bell	Prepare a demo showing additional Cohesity benefits (cloning, migration, SQL Server upgrade workflows) to present to leadership	—	Open
David Gee	Contact Becky Boardman and Olufunwa, Angela to gather information for TDA slide deck, then present to TDA on Monday	2026-05-18	Open
Ross Bell, Becky Boardman	Organize a "find the zero" strategy meeting with relevant stakeholders to identify zero/deal-breaker requirements for the Cohesity POC	—	Open

Ross Bell	Investigate whether Cohesity has implemented volume replication (previously missing feature from Veeam migration)	—	Tentative
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Open questions

- Will Cohesity's requirement for local EBS storage (as a backup landing zone before tiering to Glacier) be cost-acceptable? Olufunwa, Angela raised concerns; Ross Bell argued only short-term retention would reside on EBS. Daniel Kaminski paused the debate as premature solutionizing. Owner: UNASSIGNED.
- What is the actual cost of the Cohesity solution for EMIS's estate? Magson, Matthew noted Cohesity was previously nearly double the cost of Veritas. Olufunwa, Angela provided GP Live England figures to the vendor for estimation, but pricing is not yet received. Owner: Olufunwa, Angela.
- Does Cohesity's SQL Server adapter work reliably in AWS at EMIS's scale? Ross Bell flagged this as a critical zero requirement — the adapter had reliability issues at his previous company. Owner: Ross Bell.

Discussion

Load-bearing assumptions and the "find the zero" strategy

Becky Boardman opened by proposing the team apply Ross Bell's "load-bearing assumptions" framework to the Cohesity evaluation — identifying non-negotiable requirements ("zeros") that would make the project a non-starter if unmet. Ross Bell checked comprehension across the group and confirmed this would be the primary strategy for structuring the POC. Daniel Kaminski reinforced this toward the end, asking how to move toward a concrete set of POC requirements. Becky Boardman summarized: tackle the absolutes and deal-breakers first.

Cohesity deployment model clarification

Ross Bell explained three possible Cohesity deployment models in AWS: a fully SaaS model (data transferred to Cohesity's own accounts), a SaaS orchestrator (managing EBS snapshots, comparable to N2W), and a self-hosted model (Cohesity compute nodes installed in EMIS's own AWS accounts). He

confirmed the deployment is the self-hosted model — Cohesity software running on compute nodes within EMIS's AWS. Becky Boardman and Olufunwa, Angela confirmed this aligns with expectations that data stays in EMIS's own accounts.

Storage tiering and cost concerns

Olufunwa, Angela raised concerns about EBS storage costs, noting current backups go to S3 and that EBS at scale would be unacceptable. Ross Bell argued that Cohesity requires local EBS storage for its proprietary snapshot technology (SnapFS / SnapTree) to deliver dedup and compression benefits, but only short-term retention would remain on EBS — the majority would tier to Glacier. Magson, Matthew compared this to the existing media server architecture. Daniel Kaminski intervened, noting the team was prematurely solutionizing before getting hands on the product. Ross Bell agreed to park the details but maintained the principle that EBS-only storage is not the plan.

Previous Cohesity evaluation and pricing context

Magson, Matthew provided context that Cohesity, Rubrik, and Veeam were the three products evaluated during the original on-prem-to-AWS migration. Cohesity was nearly double the cost of Veritas at that time, which is why it was ruled out. Olufunwa, Angela added that the team was not even permitted to evaluate it due to cost. Magson, Matthew suggested pricing may have changed since Cohesity acquired Veritas and absorbed their customer base. Olufunwa, Angela noted she provided GP Live England data to the Cohesity vendor via a questionnaire for cost estimation.

N2W limitations

Ross Bell noted that N2W lacks several features: it is not AG-aware, cannot do no-recovery restores, has no orchestration capabilities, and does not support point-in-time recovery for SQL Server. He stated he does not prefer N2W and it was adopted because other options were ruled out.

Organizational awareness and TDA presentation

David Gee raised that there is very limited awareness of the Cohesity evaluation work across the wider organization. He committed to presenting to TDA on Monday and requested information from Becky Boardman and Olufunwa, Angela to prepare the slide deck.

Key technical discussions

Cohesity SnapFS/SnapTree proprietary snapshot technology

Ross Bell described Cohesity's proprietary snapshot technology — SnapFS (Snap File System) and SnapTree — as the "secret sauce" that differentiates Cohesity from competitors. This technology enables inline dedup and compression, near-instant restores, and cloning capabilities. At his previous company, it achieved 2.7x data reduction (600TB raw data stored on 200TB physical storage across SQL Server databases, application servers, file servers, and Exchange). The technology requires data to

be backed up directly to Cohesity's storage platform — benefits are not available when backing up to S3 or other external storage. Olufunwa, Angela noted that the current Veritas/NBU environment uses **MSDP / MSDPC** for dedup, which Ross Bell distinguished from Cohesity's technology as not being equivalent.

SQL Server adapter and backup capabilities

Ross Bell described the Cohesity SQL Server adapter as providing: application-aware snapshots, near-instant incremental backups after an initial full, transaction log backups, AG-awareness, automatic discovery of new databases via a shield button, tagging-based backup configuration, and point-in-time recovery. He emphasized the adapter is a critical zero requirement — it must work reliably, noting it had issues at his previous company. The adapter supports mass restore, which he contrasted with N2W's lack of mass restore for point-in-time SQL Server recovery.

Cloning for SQL Server upgrades and testing

John Cameron described using Cohesity cloning to perform near-instantaneous SQL Server version upgrades: clone a production server, upgrade SQL Server on the clone (e.g., 2019 to 2022), then copy MDF/LDF files from production — SQL Server auto-upgrades the database compatibility level on attach. The actual cutover took approximately 30 minutes. Ross Bell noted this same technology enables spinning up clones for legal investigations or dev testing — clone a production server, take a native backup from the clone, hand it off, then destroy the clone. Becky Boardman noted this could significantly reduce project timelines for Windows OS upgrades and similar migration projects, estimating what previously took six months could potentially be reduced to around 30 days.

AZ resilience and cross-AZ replication

Magson, Matthew explained that a Cohesity cluster is constrained to a single AWS Availability Zone. If that AZ is lost, the backup cluster is lost — the same risk as the current setup. The mitigation is deploying a cluster in each AZ with data replication between them. Ross Bell confirmed this matches his previous experience with dual on-prem data centres and noted Cohesity can effectively operate active-active across sites.

Current disaster recovery posture

Ross Bell presented the current recovery posture: 3 days to recover a single node, and an estimated 174 days for sequential full-estate recovery. He characterized this as a significant risk, noting parallel recovery is not feasible. N2W does not solve this adequately — it has a mass restore feature but lacks point-in-time recovery for SQL Server. Cohesity offers both mass restore and point-in-time recovery capabilities.

Breakthrough moments

- **Daniel Kaminski** raised the question of what the team needs to do to move toward a concrete set of POC requirements, redirecting the discussion from a technical deep-dive into actionable planning. This led to agreements on centralizing communications, organizing a "find the zero" strategy meeting, and reusing the N2W requirements as a baseline. *[Inferred]*

Outcomes

At the start, participants had varied understanding of Cohesity's deployment model in AWS and its capabilities relative to N2W and the current NetBackup setup. By the end, the team established that Cohesity will be self-hosted on compute nodes within EMIS's own AWS accounts (not SaaS). The "find the zero" strategy was adopted as the approach for structuring POC requirements — test deal-breakers first. An organizational awareness gap was identified and David Gee committed to presenting to TDA on Monday.

Forward look

- A dedicated "find the zero" strategy meeting will be organized with relevant stakeholders to identify deal-breaker requirements for the Cohesity POC, with targeted invitations rather than broad attendance.
- David Gee plans to present the Cohesity evaluation initiative to TDA on Monday to bridge the organizational awareness gap.
- The team plans to review existing N2W requirements and combine them with zero requirements from the strategy session to form the POC requirements submitted to Cohesity.
- Ross Bell intends to investigate whether Cohesity now supports volume replication — a feature previously available in Veeam that the platform team valued.

Architecture decisions

ADR-draft: Deploy Cohesity Data Cloud as self-hosted on AWS compute nodes

- **Status:** Proposed
- **Context:** EMIS is evaluating Cohesity as a replacement for NetBackup (Veritas, now acquired by Cohesity). Three deployment models exist: SaaS (data to Cohesity's accounts), SaaS orchestrator (EBS snapshots only, comparable to N2W), and self-hosted (Cohesity nodes in EMIS's AWS). The team needs access to Cohesity's proprietary `SnapFS / SnapTree` technology for dedup, compression, and near-instant restores, which requires backing up directly to Cohesity-managed storage.
- **Decision:** We will deploy Cohesity Data Cloud on self-hosted compute nodes within EMIS's own AWS accounts, with clusters in each AZ for resilience, short-term retention on local EBS storage, and long-term retention tiered to Glacier.

- **Consequences:**

- (+) Access to proprietary SnapFS / SnapTree technology delivering dedup, compression, near-instant restores, and cloning
 - (+) Data remains within EMIS's own AWS accounts — no third-party data residency concerns
 - (+) Cross-AZ replication provides backup resilience equivalent to dual data centre model
 - (–) Requires EBS storage for local backup landing zone before tiering, adding cost that needs validation
 - (–) Cohesity cluster is constrained to a single AZ, requiring dual clusters and replication configuration for resilience
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